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Preparing for the Future

The Indian Army's plans for modernization are based on a fifteen-year perspective plan. The need to maintain a balance between development and defence expenditure constrains us to have a proportionate mix of equipment: the state-of-the-art as well as the nearly obsolete. As far as the mechanized forces are concerned, we are focusing on night-fighting capability of the vintage equipment as well as inducting T90 and Arjun tanks.

As I visualize it, the T90 shall be our main battle tank for the next few decades. The T72 tanks are being refurbished with improved fire control, night vision and communication systems. For the artillery, we could not induct new towed 155 mm guns because the systems under trials did not meet the desired parameters. The whole exercise is being repeated on priority as the artillery badly requires new equipment. Besides that, I was convinced that we needed to acquire a capability of 155-mm light howitzers with a longer reach, which could be underslung and lifted by helicopters, specially for the mountains, and out-of-area and amphibious operations. There were some amongst us who were content with the towed guns under trial, but had no answer for areas in the mountains where there were no roads or even if there were, the guns would not have been able to reach the desired areas easily. I believe such light howitzers are now being evaluated and tried out. To meet this operational requirement, the air force is also in the process of procuring heavy lift helicopters to carry these guns and undertake other missions as well. This capability will definitely take us into the big league.

The same applies to the air defence artillery, where the equipment is almost obsolete and the shortages need to be made up. In the